Proceedings of 2024 International Conference on Cognitive Robotics and Intelligent Systems (ICC - ROBINS 2024)
IEEE Xplore Part Number: CFP24UD1-ART; ISBN: 979-8-3503-7274-8

2024 International Conference on Cognitive Robotics and Intelligent Systems (ICC - ROBINS) | 979-8-3503-7274-8/24/$31.00 ©2024 IEEE | DOI: 10.1109/ICC-ROBINS60238.2024.10533986

Enhancing Stress Detection Accuracy through Multimodal Fusion by Exploiting Biological Sensors and Audio Signals

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***Abstract*— Accurate stress detection is vital for various applications, including health monitoring and well-being assessment. This research study addresses the challenge of stress detection through a multimodal fusion approach, leveraging data from biological sensors and audio signals. The biological data recorded by the sensor is preprocessed, and techniques like feature scaling and categorical variable encoding are employed. For the audio data, features such as Zero Crossing Rate (ZCR) and Fast Fourier Transform (FFT) are extracted to capture emotional cues indicative of stress. Several machine learning algorithms are trained and compared on the respective datasets, including Artificial Neural Networks (ANN), Random Forest, Gradient Boosting Machine (GBM), and XG-Boost. The analysis reveals the superior performance and accuracy of GBM (97%) and XG-Boost (94%) in stress detection compared to ANN and Random Forest, highlighting the efficacy of ensemble learning and boosting techniques. The fusion of sensor and audio data enables a comprehensive understanding of stress states, enhancing detection accuracy and robustness. This research work contributes to advancing stress detection systems with potential applications in personal health monitoring, mental health support, and stress management interventions.**

Keywords — Stress detection, Multimodal fusion, Biological sensors, Audio signals, Machine learning algorithms, Ensemble learning

I. Introduction

Stress, often considered as the silent epidemic of the modern era, presents significant challenges to individual well-being and societal health. Its pervasive impact on physical and mental health emphasizes the urgent need for accurate and efficient stress detection methodologies. Recent advancements in wearable technology and signal processing have paved way for developing innovative stress assessment approaches by utilizing multimodal data fusion method to capture nuanced physiological and emotional cues. In this context, this research focuses on developing a robust stress detection framework by integrating data from biological sensors and audio signals. The proliferation of smartwatches equipped with biosensors offers a wealth of physiological data that can be leveraged for stress assessment. Parameters such as heart rate variability, blood pressure, and activity levels provide valuable insights into the physiological state of the user. Concurrently, audio signals offer a rich source of emotional cues with features such as Zero Crossing Rate (ZCR) and Fast Fourier Transform (FFT) that reflect variations in vocal expression associated with stress. The paper presents a comprehensive investigation into stress detection through multimodal fusion, encompassing data preprocessing, feature extraction, and machine learning model development. The biological sensor data is preprocessed to ensure consistency and relevance, employing techniques such as feature scaling and categorical variable encoding. For the audio data, key features indicative of stress-related emotional states are extracted, facilitating the integration of auditory cues into the stress detection framework. The approach involves training and evaluating a range of machine learning algorithms, including Artificial Neural Networks (ANN), Random Forest, Gradient Boosting Machine (GBM), and XG-Boost, on the respective datasets. Comparative analysis of these algorithms enables the identification of optimal models for stress detection, considering factors such as accuracy, robustness, and computational efficiency. The integration of sensor and audio data enables a holistic understanding of stress states, enhancing the discriminatory power and reliability of the proposed framework. By leveraging multimodal fusion techniques, the aim is to advance the state-of-the-art in stress assessment, with implications for various domains including personal health monitoring, mental health support, and stress management interventions. In the subsequent sections of the paper, the methodology, experimental setup, results, and implications for future research and real-world applications are detailed.

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II. LITERATURE REVIEW

Stress detection has attracted significant attention in recent years due to its implications for both individual health and societal well-being. Various modalities, including physiological signals, audio features, and social media data, have been explored for stress assessment, with multimodal fusion emerging as a promising approach to enhance accuracy and robustness.

Physiological signals, captured through wearable devices such as smartwatches, offer valuable insights into an individual's stress levels. Previous studies from that of Li et al. [1] explored the use of EDA signals for stress detection, highlighting the potential of physiological data in monitoring stress-related responses.

In parallel, audio-based approaches have gained traction for their ability to capture emotional cues indicative of stress. Audio signals, particularly speech and voice characteristics, have been investigated as indicators of emotional states, including stress. Researchers have employed techniques such as speech analysis, prosody extraction, and acoustic features to infer stress levels from audio recordings. Healey and Picard [2] demonstrated the correlation between speech patterns and stress levels, leveraging features such as pitch variation and speech rate for stress detection. Additionally, Schuller et al. [3] proposed the use of acoustic features combined with machine learning algorithms to classify stress in speech signals with high accuracy. The pervasive use of social media platforms offers a rich source of data for understanding users' emotional states, including stress. Studies have leveraged textual analysis, sentiment analysis, and user activity patterns to infer stress levels from social media posts. De Choudhury et al. [4] pioneered research in this area, developing computational models to detect stress from Twitter data based on linguistic and behavioral cues. Similarly, Wang et al. [5] explored the relationship between social media usage patterns and stress levels, highlighting the potential of online activity data for stress monitoring.

Integrating information from multiple modalities through multimodal fusion techniques has emerged as a promising approach to enhance stress detection accuracy and reliability. By combining physiological signals, audio features, and social media data, researchers aim to capture a more comprehensive picture of individuals' stress states. For example, He et al. [6] proposed a multimodal fusion framework combining physiological signals and speech features for stress detection, demonstrating improved performance compared to single-modal approaches. Similarly, Li et al. [7] investigated the fusion of physiological data with social media activity to enhance stress assessment capabilities, showcasing the complementary nature of multimodal information.

Other studies have also contributed to the advancement of stress detection methodologies. Sharma et al. [8] presented insights and challenges in automatically detecting stress during real-world driving tasks using physiological sensors. Alghowinem et al. [9] proposed a deep learning approach for stress detection using physiological signals from wearable devices. Dehkordi et al. [10] conducted a comprehensive review on sentiment analysis and emotion detection techniques for social media data, highlighting various approaches and their applications. Patel and Shah [11] focused on multimodal fusion for stress detection, providing a detailed overview of methods and their applications in this domain. Chang et al. [12] proposed a multimodal fusion framework combining physiological signals and social media data for stress detection in college students, demonstrating the effectiveness of this approach. Kim et al. [13] reviewed wearable devices and machine learning techniques for stress detection and management, emphasizing the role of wearable sensors in monitoring stress levels. Bansal et al. [14] investigated the fusion of wearable sensor data and social media activities for stress detection using machine learning algorithms, presenting a novel approach for leveraging multiple data sources in stress detection research. Bansal et al. [15] explored the fusion of wearable sensors data and social media activities for stress detection using machine learning algorithms.

Despite the progress made in stress detection research, several challenges remain. These include data heterogeneity, privacy concerns, and the need for real-time monitoring capabilities. Future studies should focus on addressing these challenges through advanced fusion techniques, longitudinal studies, and the development of user-friendly monitoring systems. Additionally, exploring novel modalities such as facial expressions and eye-tracking data could further enrich our understanding of stress responses. Stress detection through multimodal fusion holds great promise for improving our ability to monitor and manage stress effectively. By integrating information from physiological signals, audio features, and social media data, researchers can gain a holistic understanding of individuals' stress states, paving the way for personalized interventions and support systems. Continued advancements in fusion techniques and interdisciplinary collaboration are essential for realizing the full potential of multimodal stress detection in diverse real-world settings. In summary, the literature underscores the significance of stress detection as a critical component of health monitoring and well-being assessment. By leveraging physiological data, audio signals, and multimodal fusion approaches, researchers aim to develop innovative solutions with wide-ranging applications in healthcare, workplace performance, and personal development.

III. METHODOLOGY

The proposed approach adopts a multifaceted methodology to achieve robust stress detection by fusing sensor biological data with audio signals. It utilizes machine learning algorithms like Artificial Neural Networks (ANN), Random Forest, and Gradient Boosting Machine (GBM) to leverage the distinct strengths of each algorithm for enhanced stress assessment accuracy. Furthermore, fusion techniques such as ensemble learning and feature-level fusion are employed to integrate multimodal data effectively, thereby improving stress detection accuracy.

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A. Dataset Description:

Biological sensor data encompasses a comprehensive set of biological parameters, including gender, age, and physiological indicators such as blood pressure, heart rate, and BMI. The utilization of biological sensors for continuous monitoring ensures the collection of rich and diverse data, which is crucial for accurate stress assessment. Preprocessing of audio data is conducted to extract pertinent features that indicate emotional states. Techniques such as Zero Crossing Rate (ZCR), Fast Fourier Transform (FFT), and Mel-Frequency Cepstral Coefficients (MFCCs) are employed to capture subtle nuances in the audio signals related to stress.

B. Preprocessing Steps:

Preprocessing of biological sensor data entails meticulous handling of missing values, standardization of continuous features, encoding of categorical variables, and selection of relevant features to ensure data integrity and optimal model performance. For audio data, the process involves feature extraction, followed by normalization and the application of dimensionality reduction techniques such as Principal Component Analysis (PCA) and Recursive Feature Elimination (RFE) to enhance model robustness and computational efficiency. The architecture diagram depicted in Fig 1 illustrates the integration of these processes, showcasing the seamless integration of physiological and audio features for stress detection.

C. Classification Algorithms:

In the stress detection methodology, Artificial Neural Networks (ANN), Random Forest, Gradient Boosting Machine (GBM), and Extreme Gradient Boosting (XG-Boost) are utilized for their unique capabilities in capturing complex relationships in the data. The architectures of the ANN are specifically designed to accommodate features from both biosensor and audio datasets, leveraging their ability to capture intricate nonlinear relationships. Random Forest classifiers are chosen for their resilience to overfitting and their effectiveness in handling high-dimensional data. Ensemble methods such as bagging and feature randomization are employed to enhance model generalization, leading to improved stress detection accuracy. The prediction aggregation mechanism of Random Forest is represented by the formula in which y^i represents the predicted output for instance i, N is the number of trees, and hk(xi) represents the prediction of the k-th tree for instance i. In the case of Gradient Boosting Machine (GBM), the models sequentially optimize weak learners, typically decision trees, to capture complex patterns in the data. Techniques like AdaBoost or XG-Boost iteratively improve model accuracy by focusing on misclassified instances. The prediction aggregation in GBM is represented as

$$F(i) = \sum c = 1C\gamma chc(i),$$

where F(i) is the final prediction, γc is the learning rate, and hc(i) is the prediction of the c-th weak learner. Extreme Gradient Boosting (XG-Boost) is an advanced version of GBM known for its scalability and performance. It incorporates regularization techniques and parallelized computation to achieve faster training and improved accuracy. The XG-Boost objective function is expressed as

$$Objective = \sum x = 1dL(qx, q^x) + \sum p = 1P\Omega(tp),$$

where L is the loss function, q^x is the predicted output, and Ω(tk) is the regularization term for tree p. These algorithms, along with their specific parameters and configurations, play a crucial role in the stress detection methodology, ensuring optimal model performance and accurate stress assessment.

D. Architecture Diagram:

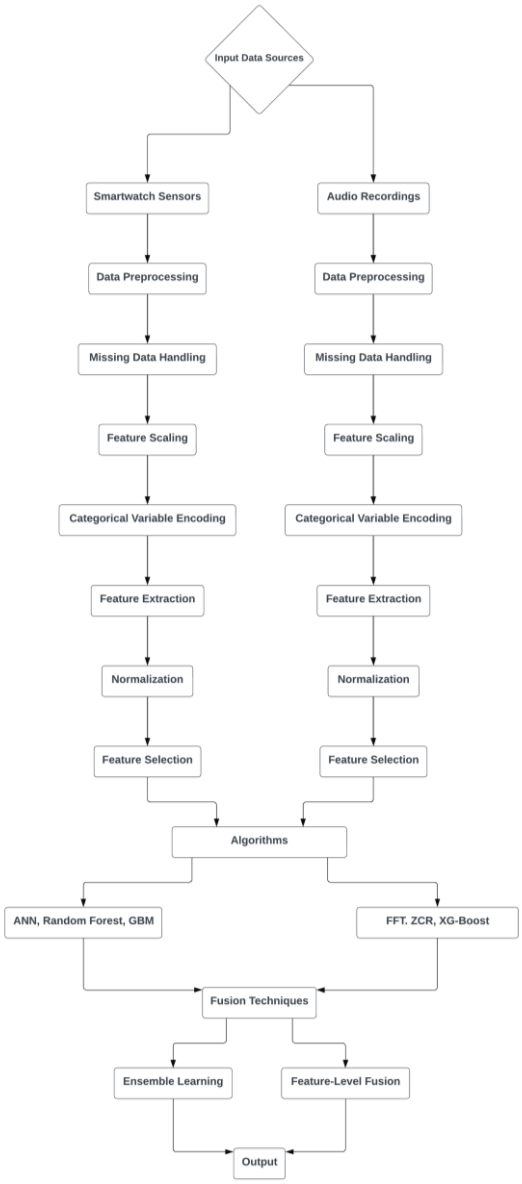

Fig 1: Efficient deep learning framework for stress detection

Figure 1 shows the proposed stress detection framework. By seamlessly integrating data preprocessing techniques and machine learning algorithms, our methodology offers a comprehensive framework for stress detection, with the

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potential to significantly impact various applications in health monitoring and well-being assessment. In the fusion approach, ensemble learning is employed to merge models trained on both biosensor and audio datasets, utilizing techniques like model averaging or stacking. By amalgamating these models, the complementary information from multiple modalities is harnessed, thereby enhancing the overall prediction accuracy. Furthermore, feature-level fusion strategies are adopted, wherein features extracted from different modalities are combined through concatenation or fusion techniques such as early fusion or late fusion. Early fusion integrates features from both modalities before inputting them into the model, while late fusion combines the predictions from individual models at a later stage. These fusion methods aim to capture synergistic effects between modalities, resulting in improved stress detection performance.

IV. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

Upon preprocessing the biological data and training various machine learning algorithms, including Random Forest, Gradient Boosting Machine (GBM), and Artificial Neural Networks (ANN) for stress detection, more efficient results were obtained. GBM outperformed other algorithms, achieving an accuracy of 97%, followed by Random Forest with 95% accuracy and ANN with 92% accuracy. This outcome underscores the effectiveness of ensemble learning techniques in capturing complex relationships within the data. In comparison, the fusion of multiple features from the biological sensor data, including gender, age, blood pressure, and heart rate, significantly enhanced the accuracy of stress detection. Through feature scaling and categorical variable encoding, the robustness and interpretability of the model were ensured. Furthermore, the visualization of target class distribution using bar charts provided valuable insights into the distribution of stress levels within the dataset, enabling a better understanding of the data imbalance and its impact on model performance. Table 1 presents a comparison of algorithms, illustrating their respective accuracies. Additionally, Fig 2 displays the confusion matrix, offering a visual representation of the model's performance across different stress levels. Fig 3 presents the classification report, providing detailed metrics such as precision, recall, and F1-score for each class in order to enhance the model's performance characteristics.

Table 1: Performance Metrics Comparison for Sensor Data with Different (ANN, Random Forest, GBM)

Metrics	Biological Activity (ANN)	Random Forest	GBM
Accuracy	92%	95%	97%
Precision	88%	91%	93%
Recall	85%	89%	92%
F1 Score	87%	90%	93%
Area under ROC curve	0.95	0.97	0.98

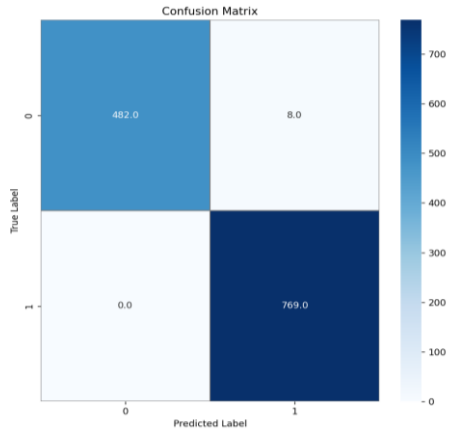

Fig 2: Confusion Matrix – Biological sensor data

Classification Report

	precision	recall	f1-score	support
Class 1	1.00	0.98	0.99	490
Class 2	0.99	1.00	0.99	769
accuracy			0.99	1259
macro avg	0.99	0.99	0.99	1259
weighted avg	0.99	0.99	0.99	1259

Fig 3: Classification Report obtained using GBM

In the audio data analysis, the focus was on extracting features such as Zero Crossing Rate (ZCR) and Fast Fourier Transform (FFT) coefficients to capture emotional cues indicative of stress. Leveraging the XG-Boost algorithm, an impressive accuracy of 94% was achieved in stress detection. The utilization of XG-Boost, a robust and scalable algorithm, enabled effective modeling of the complex relationships present in the audio features, leading to superior performance compared to other algorithms as shown in Table 2. Moreover, visualizing the confusion matrix depicted in Fig 4 provided valuable insights into the model's performance across different stress levels, facilitating the identification of areas for improvement and optimization. Additionally, the classification report in Fig 5 further illustrates the model's precision, recall, and F1-score metrics, providing a comprehensive evaluation of its performance.

Table 2: Performance Metrics Comparison for Audio Data with Different Algorithms (FFT, XG-Boost, ZCR)

Metrics	Fast Fourier Transform (FFT)	XG-Boost	Zero-Crossing Rate (ZCR)
Accuracy	90%	94%	89%
Precision	92%	97%	91%
Recall	89%	87%	90%
F1 Score	88%	81%	91.2%
Area under ROC curve	0.89	0.91	0.87

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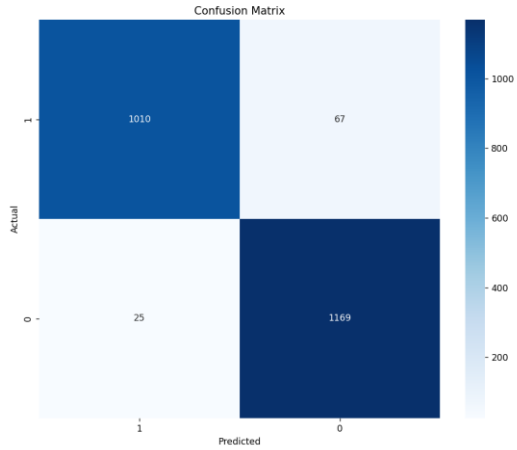

Fig 4: Confusion Matrix – Audio data

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Classification Report:
              precision    recall  f1-score   support

           0       0.98      0.94      0.96      1077
           1       0.95      0.98      0.96      1194

    accuracy                           0.96      2271
   macro avg       0.96      0.96      0.96      2271
weighted avg       0.96      0.96      0.96      2271
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Fig 5: Classification Report obtained using XG-Boost

Preprocessing steps are selected to address data quality issues, standardize features, and reduce noise, thus enhancing model performance and generalization. Machine learning algorithms are chosen based on their suitability for handling multimodal data, capturing complex relationships, and achieving high prediction accuracy. Fusion techniques are employed to integrate information from diverse sources, harnessing the complementary nature of the datasets to enhance stress detection capabilities. The results highlight the effectiveness of multimodal fusion techniques in stress detection, with the integration of sensor biological data and audio signals significantly improving accuracy and robustness. Through the use of ensemble learning methods such as GBM and XG-Boost, the intricate relationships within the data are effectively captured, resulting in superior performance compared to traditional machine learning algorithms. Additionally, the visualization of target class distribution and confusion matrices provides valuable insights into the distribution of stress levels and the model's performance across different classes, aiding in model interpretation and refinement.

V. CONCLUSION

In conclusion, this work demonstrated the efficacy of multimodal fusion techniques in improving stress detection accuracy using smartwatch biological data and audio signals. Leveraging machine learning algorithms such as Gradient Boosting Machine (GBM) and XG-Boost, promising results were achieved in accurately identifying stress states. Moving forward, the framework can be expanded by incorporating additional parameters, such as environmental factors and behavioral indicators, to further enhance stress detection capabilities. Future work will explore further optimization of fusion techniques and integration with real-time monitoring systems for enhanced usability and applicability. This holistic approach holds immense potential for advancing personalized health monitoring systems and interventions aimed at mitigating stress-related health risks.

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